

Human Research Ethics

Participant Information Statement and Consent

Anonymous surveys



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Regarding Research Project: EV & e-Bus Uptake in Lake Macquarie: Survey-Based Choice Modelling
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Dear potential research participant,

You are invited to participate in the research project noted above which is being conducted by researchers from the University of Newcastle.

This project has been funded by Lake Macquarie City Council through its Environmental Research Grants Program 2025–2026.

The information below provides more detail about the study and how you can participate, if you choose to do so.

1. What is the research study about?

The purpose of the research is to find out what would encourage people living in the Lake Macquarie and Newcastle local government areas to consider an electric vehicle (EV) for their next car, and what would make travelling by bus — including electric buses — a more attractive option than driving. Fuel and electricity prices have changed a great deal in recent years, and we would like to understand how this is affecting the everyday travel choices households make. The results will be provided to Lake Macquarie City Council to help it decide where public EV chargers are most needed, and how to plan and advocate for better local bus services.

2. Who is conducting the research?

This research project is being conducted by researchers from the University of Newcastle's Newcastle Business School. Mr Wayne Diemar of Dantia, Lake Macquarie's economic development company, is an industry research partner and advises on local context; he does not have access to any individual survey responses.

3. Who can participate in the research?

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This research study is recruiting adults aged 18 years or older who live in the Lake Macquarie local government area or in the Newcastle local government area, in New South Wales.

You have received this invitation because you are a member of the SurveyEngine online research panel, and the details you have previously registered with SurveyEngine suggest you may meet these criteria. SurveyEngine is an independent research company that manages the panel and has sent you this invitation on the researchers' behalf. The research team does not have your name or contact details and has not been given access to the panel membership list, so your privacy has not been breached.

People who cannot participate include those who are under 18 years of age, and those who do not live in either the Lake Macquarie or the Newcastle local government area.

4. What does participation involve?

If you agree to participate, you will be asked to complete an anonymous online survey about your household's everyday travel, the vehicle or vehicles you use, and your views on electric vehicles, buses and energy costs. Part of the survey asks you to look at a series of imaginary ("what if") options and pick the one you would be most likely to choose — first between an electric car, a petrol car and keeping your current vehicle, and then between travelling the way you do now and a bus service described to you. These options are hypothetical only. You are not being asked to buy anything, to commit to travelling in any particular way, or to provide any financial information about a real purchase, and there are no right or wrong answers.

The survey should take approximately 18 to 20 minutes to complete.

[The survey is designed to be completed in one session. If you close the survey before submitting it, your answers will not be saved and cannot be recovered, because the survey does not record any information that would allow us to identify you and return you to a part-completed response.](#)

5. Do you have to take part in this research study?

No. Participation in this research study is voluntary. If you do not want to take part, you do not have to. If you decide to participate and later change your mind, you are free to withdraw from the study at any time prior to submitting your completed survey. Due to the anonymous nature of the survey, if you decide to withdraw from the project after submitting a completed survey, we cannot withdraw your responses.

6. What is the benefit of participating in this research study?

By participating in this survey, you will have the opportunity to help Lake Macquarie City Council understand what local residents actually need before it decides where to place public EV chargers and how to improve and advocate for local bus services. There is no direct personal benefit to you from taking part, but your answers will contribute to better-informed local transport decisions for your community.

7. Are there any risks involved in participating in this research?

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The risks associated with participating in this research are minimal. The survey involves no physical procedures, and the main foreseeable discomfort is that you may find the repeated choice questions mildly tiring.

Some questions ask about your household's transport costs, energy bills and income. If your household is under financial pressure, you may find it uncomfortable to think about these things. Should you find any of the questions upsetting, you can stop your participation at any time prior to submission of the survey, and you may leave any question blank if you would prefer not to answer it.

You can also contact Lifeline on 13 11 14 (24-hour crisis support) or the National Debt Helpline on 1800 007 007 (free, independent financial counselling) should you need support regarding any of the issues raised in the survey.

8. How will your privacy be protected?

Due to the anonymous nature of the survey, the responses you provide will not be identifiable.

The survey is hosted by SurveyEngine, an independent online research company, on its secure survey platform; information about how SurveyEngine protects data is available in the privacy policy published on its website. We do not ask for your name, address, email address or telephone number anywhere in the survey. The only location information collected is your suburb or postcode, which is used to group responses into broad reporting areas. When data collection is complete, SurveyEngine will provide the research team with a de-identified data file, which will be stored on password-protected University of Newcastle systems accessible only to the named researchers. Data will be retained securely for a minimum period of 5 years from the date of publication of the research. Information will be managed and stored in accordance with the University's Research Data and Materials Management Guideline or any successor Guideline, as well as any other applicable University of Newcastle policy provisions.

9. How will information collected by the research team be used?

The information will be collated and analysed statistically. It will be reported to Lake Macquarie City Council in a technical report, in short policy summaries and in a scenario planning tool, and may also be presented in academic publications, at conferences or in articles. Only combined, summary results are reported — for example, average preferences across all participants, or across broad groups such as "residents who cannot charge a car at home". No identifying information about you will be provided to Lake Macquarie City Council, to Newcastle City Council, or to any other party.

A plain-English summary of the results will be made publicly available after the study is completed, through the University of Newcastle and Lake Macquarie City Council. If you would like a copy of the summary sent to you directly, please email the Chief Investigator at haoning.xi@newcastle.edu.au. Because the survey is anonymous, a request of this kind cannot be linked to your survey responses.

Individual participants will not be identifiable in any of the outputs generated from the research project, but individual anonymous responses may be quoted.

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Non-identifiable data may be shared with other parties as part of a peer-review process to verify the robustness and integrity of the study, or to contribute to further research and public knowledge.

10. What you need to do in order to participate

Read this Information Statement in its entirety and be sure you understand all of the information provided before you agree to participate.

If there is anything you do not understand, or if you have questions, contact Dr Haoning (Alice) Xi, Chief Investigator, Newcastle Business School, University of Newcastle, on [CI direct business phone to be inserted] or at haoning.xi@newcastle.edu.au.

If you would like to participate, please click on the survey link provided in your invitation from SurveyEngine and complete the online survey. If this document was provided in an electronic form you are encouraged to retain a copy for your reference.

Completion and submission of the survey will be taken as your implied consent to participate.

11. Do you need more information?

If you would like more information about this research project, please contact Dr Haoning (Alice) Xi, Chief Investigator, Newcastle Business School, University of Newcastle, on [CI direct business phone to be inserted] or at haoning.xi@newcastle.edu.au.

Thank you,

Signature goes here

Dr Haoning (Alice) Xi
Senior Lecturer, Newcastle Business School
University of Newcastle

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Concerns or complaints about this research

This project has been approved by the University of Newcastle's Human Research Ethics Committee, Approval No. H-[approval number to be inserted on approval].

If you have concerns about your rights as a participant in this research, or if you have a complaint about the manner in which the research is conducted, you can contact the Chief Investigator, Dr Haoning (Alice) Xi, on [CI direct business phone to be inserted] or at haoning.xi@newcastle.edu.au.

If you would prefer to contact someone independent of the research project, you can forward your concerns to:

Human Research Ethics Officer
Research and Innovation Services
University of Newcastle
University Drive
Callaghan NSW 2308, Australia
Phone: (02) 4921 6333
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